Q+A

OLD IS GOLD

Winning the Australian Open at 43, Rohan Bopanna has become the oldest player ever to win a slam or to hold a No. 1 ranking

Q. Your declaration "I'm not 43, I'm level 43" has struck a chord. Does level 43 feel like being on top of the world?
I am on top of the world given I am ranked number one in the world [in men's doubles]. I am proud to have achieved the feat.

Q. Sixty-one attempts until your maiden men's doubles grand slam title. There have been many hardships along the way. What kept driving you?
My perseverance has been a major strength in my journey. I had mentioned to my wife that I didn't want to continue because I wasn't winning matches and wasn't happy on court. Just expressing myself helped. I slowly started getting the belief again.... I have a wonderful partner in Matthew Ebden who has played a major part in all the success we had last year.

Q. Ebden has spoken about ageism. Did you encounter that and, if so, how did you overcome it?
Of course, I see youngsters half my age, but there's mutual respect in the locker room. They know of my journey. A lot of the guys are also inspired by it. They realise that it's not just about being fit but also about mental strength.

Q. One of your dreams is to land an Olympic medal. After your recent success and Paris months away, is that dream reignited?
Winning the grand slam ensures I remain in the top 10 of rankings—which means we definitely have a men's doubles team going to Paris. Out there, it's an equal chance. We have a good set of players, too, for me to pick a partner.

-with Nikhil Naz

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